

Career and technical education (CTE) programs specialize in preparing students to work in the skilled trades, applied sciences, and modern technologies. CTE programs offer both academic and career-oriented courses, and many provide students with the opportunity to gain work experience through internships, job shadowing, on-the-job training, and industry-certification opportunities.

This guide is designed for individuals at postsecondary CTE institutions who recognize the need to make career and technical education more accessible to students with intellectual disability. This guide provides a roadmap on how to plan for, initiate, and implement strategies for improving support for students with intellectual disability. Postsecondary CTE institutions can foster supportive and challenging environments for students with intellectual disability, ensuring their access to and success in CTE programs, through engaging people, assessing institutional readiness, and implementing inclusive practices.

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What is Career and Technical Education (CTE)?

Postsecondary career and technical education (CTE) programs focus on providing students with the skills, knowledge, and training necessary to enter a specific career field or industry. These programs typically offer hands-on, practical training in fields such as healthcare, information technology, automotive technology, construction trades, hospitality, cosmetology, and many others.

Postsecondary CTE programs can be found in various institutions, including community colleges, technical schools, and some 4-year colleges and universities. They often lead to industry certifications or other industry-recognized credentials.

These programs are designed to prepare students for the workforce quickly and efficiently by equipping them with specific skills and knowledge needed for their chosen career path. CTE programs may also include internships, apprenticeships, or cooperative education experiences that allow students to gain real-world experience while still in school.

INTRODUCTION

In your role at your CTE institution, you recognize the need to improve supports for students with intellectual disability. Perhaps you see students with intellectual disability enrolling but then struggling to complete their academic programs. Or perhaps you have a personal interest in supporting people with intellectual disability and have noticed your institution does not have many students with intellectual disability enrolled. Once you have garnered support from others at your institution, you'll need to gather information, define your goals, and proceed through a planning process.

There are two approaches for supporting students with intellectual disability to access postsecondary CTE:

1. **Existing programs with enhanced support:** Many CTE schools find that students with intellectual disability can be successful in their existing programs with some enhanced support. This approach supports students to earn recognized postsecondary credentials.
2. **New programs designed for students with intellectual disability:** Some CTE schools have developed dedicated programs for students with intellectual disability that can become approved as Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary (CTP) programs. CTP programs allow for some flexibility in admission requirements for students with intellectual disability, such as waiving the need for a high school diploma. This type of program has specific requirements as to what is included in a program of study, such as work-based learning and independent living skill instruction. It also allows for students to be able to access financial aid even when auditing coursework. In some states, offering a CTP program may mean that more funding is available for students with intellectual disability to enroll at your institution.

A blend of these two approaches is also possible, such as adding a college preparation course or module to the start of an existing credential program at the institution. The blended approach can result in a program that can become approved as a CTP program.

You do not need to know at the start of this process which of these models you plan to pursue at your institution. Through the step-by-step process outlined in this guide, you will gather the information needed to inform this decision.

STEPS FOR SUPPORTING STUDENTS WITH INTELLECTUAL DISABILITY AT YOUR CTE

- » **Step 1:** Build the Case for Improving Supports for Students with Intellectual Disability
- » **Step 2:** Assemble a Planning Group
- » **Step 3:** Gather Information and Assess Needs
- » **Step 4:** Intentionally Plan for Supports for Students with Intellectual Disability to Succeed
- » **Step 5:** Evaluate and Repeat

We outline this as a linear process, but in practice you may find yourself jumping around between steps, going back to add people to your planning group, or finding that you need to gather more information as you move through the intentional process of enhancing your supports.

Step 1: Build the Case for Improving Supports for Students with Intellectual Disability

This step is designed to help you build a strong case for why improving access and support for students with intellectual disability in CTE benefits everyone—students, faculty, employers, and the institution as a whole. It provides talking points and insights that will help you gain buy-in from key people across your institution.

The following talking points are designed to help you communicate the importance of improving support for students with intellectual disability at your institution. Use them to explain why this work benefits not only the students but also faculty, employers, and the institution as a whole. These points will help you build a compelling case when engaging colleagues, administrators, and other key people.

Benefits to Students with Intellectual Disability

CTE programs offer a wide range of benefits to students, including those with intellectual disability. For example:

- » CTE gives students the opportunity to **complete their education in as little as three months**, with little to no debt, and go on to join some of the most in-demand careers in our country.
- » CTE postsecondary programs award **meaningful credentials**. Industry recognized credentials can open the doors of employment for students with intellectual disability by showing employers how they can contribute to their business. These credentials help to change employers' mindsets about potential employees with intellectual disability by presenting the things they can do rather than focusing on deficits.
- » The **hands-on learning and strength-based skill development** that takes place in a CTE classroom works well with the learning needs of many students, including those with intellectual disability.
- » There are various **levels available in a variety of CTE careers**. For example, welding companies hire welding assistants to help their welders maximize their time on the job by having a helper handle some of the tasks.
- » CTE programs provide **multiple points of exit**. An example of this is an Automotive program that covers many different aspects of automotive repair and maintenance. Students may learn how to change the oil in a car but may struggle when it comes to electrical systems. They can still take what they have learned and become employed by a shop that focuses on oil changes.
- » The **demand for trade positions** is at the highest it has ever been. CTE provides an opportunity for students with intellectual disability to gain employment in high-demand employment areas.
- » CTE courses help students **strengthen their “soft skills”** in a natural way. For example, a student in plumbing class ends up working with a group to practice installing a sink in new construction. Without even realizing it, the student is working to solve a problem and is communicating with their team to get the job done.
- » **Learning and working in an inclusive environment** with other students gives students with intellectual disability the opportunity to increase their social-emotional skills. In many cases, these interactions are opportunities for students with intellectual disability to observe how their peers without disabilities respond in a wide range of situations.

Benefits for Colleges, Other Students, and Employers

The benefits of expanding the support available to include students with intellectual disability extend to other groups as well. For example:

- » **The use of instructional techniques to teach content that meets the needs of all learners.** As your staff begin to implement strategies like universal design for learning, all students will benefit. Finding new ways to teach content can be exciting for those instructors who truly care about their profession.
- » A focus on students with intellectual disability can help **achieve Perkins V performance targets.** (See box below to learn more about Perkins V.) Students with disabilities are one of the special populations that are included in performance targets. One of the goals of CTE programs is to **prepare their students for the real world.** Persons with disabilities are part of that world and should be part of their classroom.
- » Graduates can **return to their school districts as employees** (e.g., cafeteria workers, transportation services, clerical, paraprofessionals) School districts often have unmet employment needs in these areas and so students with intellectual disability who graduate can help fill these positions in their local school districts.

What is Perkins V?

The Perkins V Strengthening Career and Technical Education for the 21st Century Act is the reauthorization of the Carl D. Perkins Career and Technical Education Act (2006). Perkins V is a federal law that provides formula funding to states, local education agencies, community and technical colleges, and other eligible entities to develop, coordinate, implement, or improve high-quality career and technical programs of study that help students gain knowledge and technical and employability skills necessary for success in a chosen career.

Perkins V includes specific provisions that emphasize the importance of career and technical education (CTE) on improving postschool outcomes for students with disabilities. Perkins V designates people with disabilities as one of nine “special populations.”

For more information on how Perkins V, read the Think College Fast Fact: [Strengthening Career and Technical Education for the 21st Century Act \(Perkins V\): Access and Opportunities in Career and Technical Education \(CTE\).](#)



FAST FACTS

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Strengthening Career and Technical Education for the 21st Century Act (Perkins V): Access and Opportunities in Career and Technical Education (CTE)

By Jacques Hyatt and W. Drew Andrews

In 2018, the Strengthening Career and Technical Education for the 21st Century Act reauthorized the Carl D. Perkins Career and Technical Education Act (2006). The law is often referred to as Perkins V, and we refer to it as Perkins V in this brief. This law provides formula funding to states, local education agencies, community and technical colleges, and other eligible entities to develop, coordinate, implement, or improve high-quality career and technical programs of study that help students gain knowledge and technical and employability skills necessary for success in a chosen career. Perkins V also strengthens the connections between secondary and postsecondary education, increasing opportunities for students to access programs of study more seamlessly as they move from high school to postsecondary education.

INCREASED OPPORTUNITIES FOR STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

Perkins V includes specific provisions that emphasize the importance of career and technical education (CTE) on improving postschool outcomes for students with disabilities. Perkins V designates people with disabilities as one of nine “special populations.” Key provisions related to “special populations” include:

- **Performance targets:** States must set annual performance targets that require the state agencies and subrecipients to “continually make meaningful progress toward improving the performance of all CTE students,” including students who are members of special populations, and identify gaps in performance between members of special populations and their peers.
- **Strategies for special populations:** To receive assistance under Perkins V, states must prepare a state plan that describes the state’s program strategies for special populations.
- **Set aside funding:** States are required to use 0.1 percent of their state leadership funds, or \$500,000 (whichever is less) for the recruitment of special populations, including students with disabilities, to enroll in CTE programs.
- **Needs assessment:** To receive Perkins V funds, subrecipients must conduct a comprehensive local needs assessment related to CTE at least every two years and include the results of the needs assessment in their local application for funds. The assessment must include an evaluation of the strategies implemented to overcome barriers that result in lower rates of access to, or performance gaps in, CTE courses and programs for special populations.
- **Equal access:** Subrecipients must describe how they will provide activities to prepare special populations for high-skill, high-wage, or in-demand industry sectors or occupations in competitive, integrated settings; provide equal access to CTE courses and programs of study to members of special populations; and ensure that members of special populations will not be discriminated against.
- **Out of pocket expenses:** Subrecipients may use their funds to reduce or eliminate out-of-pocket expenses for students who are members of special populations participating in CTE by supporting the costs associated with fees, transportation, childcare, or mobility supports for those special populations.

Strategies for Building Buy-In and Momentum

Starting this process requires collaboration and that starts with getting people at your institution to not only understand the importance of supporting students with intellectual disability but to actively join the effort.

- » **Start with the why.** Use the talking points to highlight how supporting students with intellectual disability benefits everyone—students, faculty, and employers.
- » **Identify key champions.** Look for individuals within your institution who are naturally aligned with this mission, such as those in student support services, disability resources, or instructors who have already shown interest in educating students with disabilities. These individuals can help you spread the message and gain traction.

Tip: *Use success stories or examples from other CTE schools to illustrate the real-world impact of recruiting students with intellectual disability. People are more likely to get on board when they see tangible results.*

Example: A CTP program at a technical college in Florida had a few students in the Professional Culinary Arts and Hospitality program. To help students prepare for the upcoming ServSafe Manager exam, the program coordinator created a study session with a PowerPoint, study guide, and Kahoot to help students in the CTP program prepare for the exam. In the first study session, only the students in the CTP program attended. The next day, those students told their fellow students about the study session. The second session saw the same students from the CTP, along with a few other students from class. By the third session, every student in the program was taking part in the study sessions. That cohort had the highest percentage of students pass the ServSafe Manager exam. Since then, students from various programs have participated in study sessions led by CTP program staff.

Tip: *Engage instructors or staff who are already leaders in accessibility efforts and involve them in early conversations to leverage their credibility and influence.*

Example: When asked about a student with an intellectual disability taking his class, Mr. Mayes, a plumbing instructor at a technical college, lit up because his nephew has a son with an intellectual disability who works as a plumbing assistant at his nephew's plumbing business. In another instance, an incoming president for a large technical college had a background in K-12 education and knew the value of inclusive education for students with disabilities. As soon as he became president of the college, he implemented initiatives to increase the inclusion of students with intellectual disability on campus and in the classrooms.

Quintin Davis completed the University of Arkansas–Pulaski Technical College's 3D Program specializing in Culinary Arts, and earned credentials including Servsafe Food Handler Certification and the designation of Certified Fundamental Cook (CFC®) from the American Culinary Federation. In his final year, Quintin landed a job at Blue Cake Company, a family-owned bakery in Little Rock, Arkansas, where he has been promoted to Main Baker.



Quintin Davis

Step 2: Assemble a Planning Group

To make meaningful progress in supporting students with intellectual disability at your institution, you'll need to convene a diverse group of people who share your commitment and enthusiasm. Bringing together people in different roles and from different offices or departments as well as the community will ensure a more comprehensive and intentional approach to your planning efforts.

The group you assemble will need to be composed of people who can assist you with the planning and implementation process. This list of suggested group members can help you to conceptualize who you will need at your institution.

Planning Group Members

The group should include individuals from different areas of the institution and community, ensuring a well-rounded approach to your planning efforts. For example:

Collaborating with these various individuals and offices also helps with increasing overall awareness of the services and supports available to students with intellectual disability on a campus.

Administrators: These people may hold the titles of Director, Assistant Director, President, Vice President, or Dean. Your administrative team needs to be on board with whatever it is you plan on implementing. Administrators are also helpful with personnel issues and with scheduling professional development.

Disability Resources/Accessibility Services: It is important to have someone in the group who has experience working with students with disabilities at your institution. This person will be familiar with efforts at the institution to enroll and support other students with disabilities. This person will also be familiar with institutional supports for faculty in topics such as Universal Design for Learning and other strategies that can provide support for students with intellectual disability.

Instructors: It is important to include instructors from high demand content areas in your group. Having an instructor, or instructors, as a part of your group gives them a voice in the process and an opportunity to provide meaningful input. In addition to being an expert in their field, they may also have great ideas when it comes to accommodations and support for students.

Admissions Specialist: These individuals likely have had experience with applicants with waiver-based diplomas and may offer insight into the admissions process.

Financial Aid Specialists: These individuals can navigate federal financial aid, including Pell grants, to ensure clear access to funding support for students. The financial aid office is an important partner if/when you plan to apply for approval for a Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary (CTP) program.

Career Services and External Partners: Local employers can create employment opportunities for students after graduation. Working with employers will ensure that they know how well students are prepared by the program and their value as potential employees. Communicating with employer groups, such as Rotary Clubs and Chambers of Commerce, can also help to open pathways for employment opportunities as members learn about your efforts to support students with intellectual disability.

Community Organizations: Partnering with community organizations like The Arc or local vocational rehabilitation agencies can help with identifying the potential students who would be interested in pursuing CTE once they are aware of your institution's dedicated efforts to support students with intellectual disability. Find your local VR agency on the [RSA's website](#)

Action Steps Once the Group is Assembled

Once the group is assembled, host a kickoff meeting where group members can identify common goals, share concerns, and start brainstorming actionable steps. Begin by discussing the overall mission of supporting students with intellectual disability and how it aligns with your institution's values. Set clear, specific goals that the group wants to achieve, whether that's increasing enrollment of students with intellectual disability, improving accessibility, and/or expanding support services. Develop a shared understanding of what success looks like and how it will be measured.

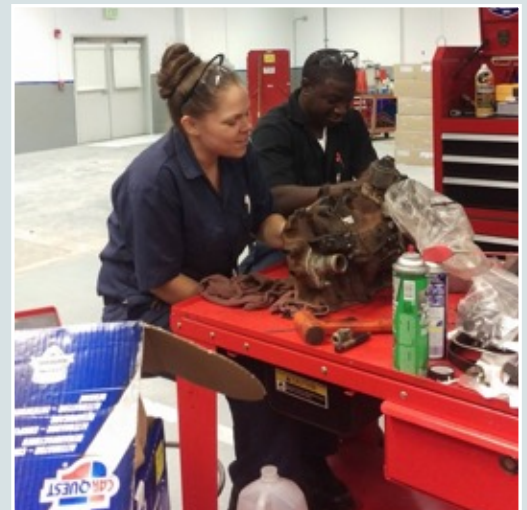
It's important to identify the strengths and expertise of each group member and assign roles and responsibilities accordingly. For example, a disability services representative may lead accessibility planning, while a faculty member may focus on curriculum adjustments. Make sure each person understands their role and is accountable for specific tasks or areas of the plan.

Develop a realistic timeline for achieving key goals. Break the larger objectives into smaller, manageable milestones to maintain momentum. Set deadlines for actions like conducting a needs assessment, increasing campus-wide awareness, or improving academic supports. Regularly check in on progress to keep the group aligned and adjust timelines as needed.

Foster communication and collaboration by establishing regular meetings to discuss progress, address challenges, and celebrate wins. Create a space where group members feel comfortable sharing ideas, concerns, and feedback. Use collaborative tools like shared documents or a project management platform to track progress and ensure everyone has access to the latest information.

Bringing people together may not be a linear process. As your work gains attention, you may find more people who are interested in joining your group and you will likely find you need to bring in people with additional expertise as your goals become clearer. Embrace the organic nature of the work and be sure to keep good notes so that you can onboard new people as they join your group.

Patrick Jacquet earned multiple certifications through the Automotive Service Technician program at Ft. Myers Technical College with support through the How I Reach Employment (HIRE) program. He now works full-time for the School District of Lee County as a Service Technician.



Patrick and his co-worker, Sarah, work to repair an engine for a maintenance department vehicle.

Step 3: Gather Information and Assess Needs

Before implementing new initiatives, it is important to understand the existing landscape of resources and needs at your institution. This section provides guidance on gathering information that will help with planning and decision-making.

We begin by listing key areas to assess along with action steps and data sources to use.

KEY AREA	DESCRIPTION	ACTION STEPS
Assess Local Employment Needs	Begin by researching the job market in your area to understand which industries are growing and in need of skilled workers. This will help align your programs with local employment opportunities for students with intellectual disability.	• Gather data on employment trends from local workforce boards, chambers of commerce, or labor market reports. • Consult with your institution's career specialists to gain insights into current and future career opportunities. • Review your institution's comprehensive local needs assessment (required for Perkins V subrecipients).
Evaluate Institutional Demand	Identify whether your institution is already enrolling students with intellectual disability or if there is an emerging need to serve this population. Understanding the current demand can guide how you shape your approach and allocate resources.	• Review any available data to see if students with intellectual disability are already enrolled. • Collaborate with admissions, financial aid, and administrative offices to assess the potential demand for programs that support this student population.
Clarify the Reason for Action	Determine why your institution is focused on improving support for students with intellectual disability. Is it driven by legislative changes, funding opportunities, or a strategic decision to increase options for students with intellectual disability?	• Review any recent state-level funding or legislation that supports students with disabilities. • Discuss with institutional leadership to understand if this initiative is part of broader strategic goals or external mandates.
Identify Enrollment and Success Challenges	Understand the challenges that students with intellectual disability face when enrolling at your institution. These could include academic challenges, such as placement tests, or institutional challenges, like limited support services.	• Analyze retention and completion data for students with disabilities to pinpoint where they may face difficulties. • Review performance reports prepared for Perkins V funding. • Consult with admissions staff to determine enrollment challenges, such as placement tests or the high school diplomas students with intellectual disability enter with. • Consult with advising staff to identify challenges related to academic requirements like prerequisites. • Consult with financial aid staff to determine issues with funding eligibility. • Consult with instructors regarding challenges they face in supporting these students.
Leverage Opportunities for Support	Explore available funding, scholarships, and resources that could enhance your institution's ability to support students with intellectual disability. Being proactive in securing these opportunities will help sustain your initiatives. Consider whether you can leverage Perkins V funding to enhance support for students with intellectual disability.	• Research state-level funding programs, such as Perkins V, vocational rehabilitation, or specific scholarships for students with disabilities. • Work with disability services and financial aid offices to ensure students can access the available resources and funding streams.



Decision Point: Will your Institution Expand Existing Supports or Develop a Dedicated Program?

Through the information-gathering process, you have assessed whether the campus has the resources to support students with intellectual disability. In many cases, with a concerted effort and additional collaboration, existing offices and personnel can focus on supporting students with intellectual disability to be successful in the current offerings of the institution. In some cases, the institution will need to put additional programming and supports in place, such as through a CTP program.

If at this point you decide that developing a CTP program is the right way to proceed at your institution, [we refer you to Think College's program development resources](#).

Step 4 will focus on expanding and improving existing supports to include students with intellectual disability through the current offerings, offices, and personnel of the institution.

Are you still not sure which model is right for your institution? Schedule a call with one of Think College's technical assistance providers to help you think through the best way to proceed. You can send an email to thinkcollegeTA@umb.edu to schedule a call.

Monae Hylor, a student at College of the Florida Keys, is taking classes towards a Hospitality associates degree with a career goal of running a bed and breakfast.



Monae, in chef's attire.

Step 4: Intentionally Plan for Supports for Students with Intellectual Disability to Succeed

In this step, you'll begin leveraging existing resources to support the success of students with intellectual disability at your institution. Here are some important areas to examine existing supports and determine if changes or enhancements are needed:

- » Institutional offerings
- » Pre-enrollment supports
- » Academic and other supports, including disability services
- » Professional development and awareness raising
- » Student funding sources

In each of these areas, we describe considerations or questions to ask to ensure supports are adequate for students with intellectual disability. We provide examples or tips from other institutions. You may find you are not able to tackle everything on this list; rather, you can use this list as a guide for selecting areas on which to focus your efforts.

Institutional Offerings

When evaluating your institution's offerings, it's important to identify if you have programs that provide an entry level for students with intellectual disability. While it's essential not to limit these students to specific programs, providing access points that allow them to begin their postsecondary education journey is key.

Example - Model of Supports

The key to supporting students with intellectual disability within CTE programs is to establish supports and services that are available to them as they go through a course of study and earn a credential. One example of where this is happening for students is Albany Technical College in Albany, GA.

Notable features of the Albany Tech approach:

- A specific admissions process for students with intellectual disability
- A wide array of certificate programs available to students with intellectual disability that are also available to all students
- Mentoring supports
- Partnership with disability resources office (the director of the program is over all disability supports at the college)
- Support to participate in all aspects of campus life

Learn more about [Albany Tech's LEAP Program](#) on their website and [watch this video of LEAP Director Regina Watts talking about the program.](#)



You may have found through your information-gathering process that you already have some programs with students with intellectual disability enrolled. Examining these programs can provide insights into why students are choosing the programs and help you understand what makes these programs accessible and appealing. Talk with both students and faculty involved in these programs to get firsthand insights. What aspects of the program are working well for students with intellectual disability? Are there specific supports, teaching methods, or flexible options that make these programs particularly welcoming? Faculty can often provide useful feedback on instructional practices and any accommodations that contribute to student success. Also look at the structure of these programs to determine whether certain elements—such as flexible entry requirements, modified course formats, or the availability of learning support—are making them more accessible. These insights can help inform how to adapt other programs at your institution to better support students with intellectual disability.

Also look at the licensing requirements of your existing offerings. Students with intellectual disability may successfully complete coursework and work experience requirements but then experience challenges with licensing exams. For credential programs with licensing exams, research the availability of disability-related accommodations that students can request to determine if these exams can be successfully completed by students with intellectual disability with appropriate accommodations. Also think about whether you have a range of offerings in which students can earn credentials without the need for licensing exams.

Look at whether there are existing programs that build in opportunities to earn microcredentials. Some certifying bodies, such as Safety & Pollution Prevention (S/P2) or the National Center for Construction Education and Research (NCCER), offer microcredentials that can lead to employment and allow students to demonstrate specific skills without needing a full degree.

Shorter certificate programs can be a good entry point for students with intellectual disability, but these programs may not meet federal financial aid requirements due to credit-hour minimums. If you are interested in opening access to students with intellectual disability in these programs with financial aid as an option, use the CTP program process to open up financial aid access for students pursuing these credentials.

Pre-Enrollment Supports

Before students with intellectual disability enter the classroom, it's crucial to ensure they have access to the right pre-enrollment supports that set them up for success. Evaluating and improving the application process, developing on-ramp programs that ease the transition to college, and helping students explore career pathways to guide them in selecting CTE programs can create a more welcoming environment for students from the very start of their postsecondary education journey.

- » **Application Processes:** A key component of establishing a welcoming entry point for students with intellectual disability is ensuring that the application process is accessible and clear. Think about whether the language in your application is easy to understand. Could you simplify the instructions? Also consider multiple submission methods as alternatives to digital-only submission processes. Ensuring that students can apply in various formats (online, paper, in-person) increases accessibility.
- » **On-Ramp Programs:** Some CTE institutions have created “on-ramp” programs that prepare students to participate in college-level coursework. You can offer these programs to students with intellectual disability who are applying to the institution. You can leverage existing resources and programming at the institution to increase the support to students with intellectual disability, such as pre-college courses, learning labs, and introductory courses taken by all students.

- » **Career Pathway Exploration:** Students with intellectual disability may need additional support to determine their career pathways of interest. Administer career interest surveys or assessments to help students with intellectual disability identify CTE programs that match their interests and abilities. You can tailor tools like the O*NET Interest Profiler or other career exploration assessments to different ability levels. Work with your campus' career advisors and counselors to ensure students complete these assessments early in their academic journey, ideally during orientation or a pre-enrollment phase.

You can provide one-on-one career counseling sessions to discuss the results of career interest surveys. Advisors can guide students through their options, helping them understand which career pathways may be a good fit based on personal strengths. Identify career advisors who have experience working with students with disabilities or offer specialized training to support these professionals.

Academic and Other Supports

Providing robust academic and non-academic support is essential to the success of students with intellectual disability at your institution. Evaluating and enhancing key resources, including disability resources, can help ensure that students receive the guidance and resources they need to be successful both in and out of the classroom.

- » **Disability Resources:** CTE institutions typically have a dedicated Disability Resource Office (DRO) or coordinator who coordinates disability resources for all students at the institution. The DRO works with students and faculty to implement reasonable accommodations tailored to individual needs. This can include extended test-taking time, note-taking assistance, alternative formats for instructional materials, and the use of assistive technologies and assistance for students in obtaining accommodations for certification exams. The office connects students with learning labs, tutoring services, and other academic supports that enhance their learning experience. The DRO serves as an advocate for students, ensuring that faculty and staff are aware of their legal obligations under disability law, such as the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act. The office often works to raise awareness across campus, providing professional development for faculty and staff on how to create accessible learning environments and how to effectively support students with disabilities.

The staff of your DRO should be key collaborators in the process of improving supports to students with intellectual disability. It's important for staff of this office to evaluate if they feel confident in their abilities to support students with intellectual disability or if they need professional development in this area.

- » **Other Academic and Social Supports:** Students with intellectual disability can benefit from a range of other academic and social supports beyond legally required accommodations. Some ways to enhance the support your institution provides to these students include tutoring sessions, focusing on areas where students with intellectual disability may struggle, such as preparation for certification exams. Peer mentoring programs where students with intellectual disability are paired with experienced peers are another great way to enhance both the academic and social support available to students.

Professional Development and Awareness Raising

Building an accessible and inclusive campus culture requires ongoing professional development and awareness efforts. Equipping faculty, staff, and administrators with the tools and knowledge needed to support students with intellectual disability can help to create a more welcoming and supportive environment for all learners.

- » **Professional Development for Faculty:** Many faculty lack knowledge and experience in how to effectively support students with intellectual disability in the classroom. Your institution can use Perkins V funds for instructor professional development. Train faculty in Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles to ensure that students with intellectual disability can engage and demonstrate their knowledge in various ways. Faculty can offer hands-on learning opportunities or alternative assessments for students to demonstrate their learning, like project-based evaluations or oral presentations. Consider offering mentoring opportunities or incentives to entice faculty to adopt UDL in their teaching practices.
- » **Awareness Across All Student Services:** All offices and staff who interact with students should be aware of and trained in supporting students with intellectual disability. Ensuring that staff in these areas are trained to provide responsive services can significantly enhance the student experience and promote success across all aspects of campus life. As you progress through your efforts to support the enrollment of students with intellectual disability, reach out to student services to educate them about your work. Key offices to include in your awareness raising efforts include:
 - Admissions
 - Advising
 - Career Services
 - Mental Health Counseling
 - Financial Aid Services

Nathan Benson, a student at Taft College, worked as an After School Assistant for the STEM & CTE department, working 24 hours a week. He gained recognition as the college's "3D printing guru," designing and printing the new Taft College Bookstore Carpe Diem seal, along with numerous other projects for the campus.



Taft College student Nathan Benson, shows off the Taft College Bookstore Carpe Diem seal that he designed and printed.

Student Funding Sources

Access to funding is critical for supporting students with intellectual disability in postsecondary education. Understanding the available resources can help institutions ensure students receive the financial support they need as well as the financial support needed by your institution to support the improvement of student supports. A few key funding sources and partnerships to explore include vocational rehabilitation, Perkins V, and grant funds.

- » **Partnering with Vocational Rehabilitation (VR):** Collaboration with VR agencies can provide students with intellectual disability opportunities for work-based learning experiences, which are often a key component of CTE. Through these partnerships, VR can help support and/or fund job coaching, internships, and other experiential learning opportunities. CTE programs can use VR funds to support students in pursuing postsecondary education to help them achieve a career goal.
- » **Perkins V Funding:** Perkins V provides funding to CTE programs and includes provisions for serving students from special populations, including those with disabilities. Institutions can use these funds to create accessible learning environments, support professional development, and provide resources for students with intellectual disability. Consult resources like the [Perkins V Special Populations Brief](#) to learn more about how to use Perkins V funds to enhance supports provided to students with disabilities.
- » **Grant Funds:** There are many grant funding opportunities your institution can use to develop or enhance academic programs for students with intellectual disability. An example of a federal grant is the [Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities \(TPSID\)](#) model demonstration program. TPSID grants provide financial support to institutions offering comprehensive transition programs for students with intellectual disability. Ask if your institution has a grant writer who can assist you in applying for grant funds.

At any time in this process, it can be worth revisiting the possibility of applying to become approved as a CTP program. We encourage you to reach out to the technical assistance providers at Think College if you find that lack of access to financial aid is causing a barrier to the enrollment of students with intellectual disability at your institution.

Isaac Rodriguez, a student at University of North Texas, took a Hospitality Management Class to prepare for a career goal of owning his own food truck.



Isaac in a cooking lab for the Hospitality Management Class

Step 5: Evaluate and Repeat

As with any initiative, ongoing evaluation is key to ensuring that supports for students with intellectual disability are effective and continuously improving. In this final step, we provide suggestions for evaluating and sustaining momentum for your efforts.

Evaluating your Efforts

The process of improving access and support for students with intellectual disability at your CTE institution is not a one-time project; it's a long-term shift. It's important for your planning group to commit to continuous improvement by setting clear goals, regularly assessing progress, and adjusting as needed.

Assess the outcomes of your efforts by gathering feedback from students, staff, and other constituents. Revisit the data points you gathered in Step 3 and see how you compare over time. Are you seeing an increase in the number of students with intellectual disability enrolling? Which academic programs are they choosing? Are they continuing through to program completion? Continuously evaluate these data points to identify what is working, address challenges, and refine processes. Committing to this cycle of evaluation and improvement will enable you to build sustainable, inclusive practices that grow stronger over time.

Sustaining Momentum:

In addition to evaluating your efforts, it's important to sustain interest in the work you are doing. People are more likely to take action when they see results early on. Start by implementing a few small, visible changes that can have an immediate impact—like improving the accessibility of your application process or offering a workshop on UDL for faculty. Share early successes with the broader campus community to build excitement and demonstrate that progress is happening. Use data or feedback from students to show how these changes are making a difference.

Recognize that some staff and faculty may have concerns or feel unsure about how to best support students with intellectual disability. Create spaces for open dialogue, where people can express their thoughts, ask questions, and learn from one another. Hold informal lunch-and-learn sessions or small group discussions focused on topics like accommodating learners with disabilities, collaborating with disability services, or adjusting teaching strategies. Offering a space for conversation can reduce resistance to change and help build confidence.

Conclusion

Creating an accessible and inclusive environment for students with intellectual disability in CTE requires collaboration, assessment, and intentional action. The process outlined in this guide—assembling a diverse group, gathering necessary data, and building on existing resources—can help CTE institutions open new postsecondary education pathways to success for students with intellectual disability, ensuring they have the opportunity to thrive in the workforce and beyond.

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